

It's up to you to start building that foundation from your very first date.



Dating is a racket. It's an endless cavalcade of dashed hopes and squandered dollars, yet for some reason, people keep coming back to it. Ever wonder why dating shows are the bread and butter of reality television? People tune in to *The Bachelor* every week hoping the contestants will find "true love." The more tears and breakdowns they encounter along the way, the higher the ratings. Because true love is worth any cost, right?

Wrong. In real life, this approach will send you straight to the poorhouse (and it doesn't seem to be working wonders for reality TV stars, either). The last thing you want is the financial burden of multiple breakups. Your goal is to find a mate and stay with him or her *for your entire life*. I want you to be happy—not just emotionally, but financially. Thank goodness you've found me: I'm here to guide you toward financial happiness. There's a reason this chapter is called "The Dating Game." You have to play to win.

Money Mistake: *You Think Dating Means Spending*

The Fix: *Avoid the Four Common Money Leaks*

When you're dating, you naturally want to put your best foot forward. Who doesn't want to look great and be charming? But the more you puff yourself up into something you're not, the more it's going to cost you later. Keeping your ego nicely stroked is not cheap. It's also not worth it. When you *do* meet the person you're going to spend the rest of your life with, why on earth would you want to start your relationship in debt?

There are four common money leaks in dating, four incidentals that slowly sap away more dollars than you realize: transportation, fancy dinners, expensive clothes and online dating sites.